Mark Scheme (Results)

History

Paper 3: Modern depth study

Option 31: Weimar and Nazi Germany, 1918-39

Mock Paper 2 (NotebookLM Prediction) - Teacher Copy

SECTION A

Answer ALL questions in this section.

1 Give two things you can infer from Source A about cultural changes in the Weimar Republic. (4)

* **(i) What I can infer:** I can infer that the cultural changes of the Weimar "Golden Age" caused deep social division and were viewed by traditionalists as a sign of moral decay.

* *Details in the source that tell me this:* The source states that the author believes the new culture represents "moral decline and the death of German culture".

* **(ii) What I can infer:** I can infer that the Weimar Constitution actively protected and enabled this cultural experimentation.

* *Details in the source that tell me this:* The source notes that when the author complained, his colleagues pointed out that "this is 'freedom of expression' guaranteed by our new constitution".

2 **Explain why there was a "Golden Age" of cultural development in Weimar Germany in the years 1924–29.** (12)

*You **may** use the following in your answer:*

- Expressionism
- The Bauhaus school

*You **must** also use information of your own.*

The Weimar Republic between 1924 and 1929 experienced a spectacular cultural flowering, often referred to as the "Golden Age," which was driven by a combination of political, economic, and technological factors. The primary catalyst for this development was the political freedom guaranteed by the new Weimar Constitution. Under the old Kaiserreich, strict government censorship had stifled artistic expression, forcing artists to conform to traditional, patriotic styles. However, the Weimar Constitution guaranteed absolute freedom of speech and the press. Consequently, this removed all pre-war censorship, allowing writers, artists, and directors to experiment with bold, controversial ideas without fear of arrest. This newfound freedom turned Berlin into the avant-garde capital of Europe, attracting creative minds from across the world.

Furthermore, this freedom of expression found its most powerful artistic outlet in the movement known as Expressionism. Expressionist artists, such as George Grosz and Otto Dix, rejected traditional, idealized art. Instead, they believed that art should depict raw emotion and the gritty, often seedier reality of everyday Weimar life. They used their paintings to make powerful social and political criticisms, depicting war-disabled veterans, poverty, and political hypocrisy on the streets of Berlin. This artistic experimentation extended directly into architecture and design through the Bauhaus school, founded by Walter Gropius in Dessau in 1925. Bauhaus design stressed that beauty lay in functionality, modern technology, and clean, simple lines, completely challenging traditional, ornate pre-war architecture. This architectural revolution was heavily supported by government funding, which saw the Bauhaus style as a progressive symbol of the new democratic republic.

Finally, this cultural explosion was facilitated by the economic recovery led by Gustav Stresemann, which provided both state funding and disposable income. With hyperinflation solved and US loans flooding into the country under the Dawes Plan, the German government and local councils had the financial means to fund public libraries, theaters, and museums. Furthermore, as living standards rose and working hours were reduced, ordinary Germans had more leisure time and disposable income to spend on cultural activities, such as cinema and cabaret. Technological developments, such as the rise of mass media, also played a crucial role. The German film industry became the most innovative in Europe, producing pioneering films like Fritz Lang’s sci-fi epic *Metropolis* in 1927. Thus, the synergy of constitutional freedom, artistic rebellion, and American-funded economic prosperity created the unique conditions for Weimar's "Golden Age".

Turn over ▶

3 **Explain why the Nazi Party was reorganised in the years 1924–28.** (12)

*You **may** use the following in your answer:*

- Landsberg Prison / Mein Kampf
- Gauleiters

*You **must** also use information of your own.*

The reorganisation of the Nazi Party between 1924 and 1928 was a critical turning point that transformed a chaotic, violent paramilitary group into a highly structured, national political machine. The primary catalyst for this shift was the failure of the Munich Putsch in November 1923, which resulted in Hitler being imprisoned in Landsberg Prison for high treason. During his nine months in prison, Hitler wrote *Mein Kampf*, in which he formulated his core ideology and, crucially, realized that the Nazi Party could no longer seize power through violent, armed revolution. Instead, Hitler decided to adopt the "legal route," meaning the party had to participate in democratic elections to destroy the Weimar Republic from within. Consequently, this strategic shift required a complete overhaul of the party's structure to enable effective national electoral campaigns.

To achieve this national reach, Hitler divided Germany into 35 regions, known as *Gaue*, which matched the electoral districts of the Reichstag. To lead each region, Hitler appointed a trusted lieutenant called a *Gauleiter*, who was directly responsible for spreading Nazi propaganda and organizing local party branches. This federal structure was tightly controlled from the new party headquarters in Munich, where Hitler established a centralized bureaucracy, appointing a Party Secretary and a Party Treasurer to manage party funds. Furthermore, to secure absolute control over this expanding organization, Hitler asserted the *Führerprinzip* (the Leadership Principle), which demanded absolute obedience to him as the supreme leader. As part of this drive for personal security and loyalty, Hitler also established the SS (Schutzstaffel) in 1925, as an elite bodyguard unit designed to be unquestionably loyal to him, reducing his dependence on the rowdy and unreliable SA.

Finally, the party had to be reorganised to crush internal ideological divisions that threatened to split the movement. By 1925, a deep rift had emerged between the northern German Gauleiters, led by Gregor Strasser, who emphasized the "socialist" elements of the 25-Point Programme, and the southern German faction, led by Hitler, who prioritized "nationalism" and anti-Semitism. To resolve this, Hitler called the Bamberg Conference in February 1926. At this conference, Hitler spoke for over two hours, systematically associating socialism with communism, which he knew the party despised. He successfully asserted his absolute authority, winning over key northern figures like Joseph Goebbels. Strasser's socialist-leaning proposals were abandoned, the 25-Point Programme was declared unalterable, and Hitler's position as undisputed *Führer* was permanently cemented. This internal pacification ensured the party was fully unified and ready to exploit the economic crisis of 1929.

SECTION B

For use with Section B, Answer ALL questions.

Source B: From a secret Gestapo report on religious attitudes in Upper Bavaria, July 1937.

"We must report that the influence of the Catholic Church on the rural population remains unbroken. The Nazi spirit cannot penetrate these districts because the local population is entirely under the influence of the priests. These people prefer to believe what the priests say from the pulpit rather than the words of our best party speakers. When our officials attempted to remove crucifixes from the local schoolrooms, women gathered in protest, and we had to restore them to prevent civil unrest. The Concordat prevents us from making direct arrests of these priests during church services, which they exploit to spread subtle criticisms of the government's youth policies."

Source C: From a sermon preached by Pastor Martin Niemöller in Berlin, June 1937.

"We have no more desire than our fathers to stand in judgment over our rulers, but we must obey God rather than men. Our brother pastors are being arrested because they spoke the truth. The government's Reich Church seeks to replace the Cross of Christ with the Swastika, and to force our children into youth organisations that teach them to worship a man. We are told that if we remain silent, the Church will have peace. But I say to you, a silent Church is a dead Church. We must speak out, even if it leads us to the concentration camps."

Interpretation 1: From The Third Reich by Dr. Elizabeth Wilmott, published in 1997.

"The Christian Churches in Germany were largely successful in resisting the Nazi regime's attempts to achieve total control over religious life. Despite intense pressure, both the Catholic and Protestant Churches prevented the total Nazification of their institutions. The Concordat of 1933 protected the Catholic Church's independence, and when Hitler broke this agreement, the Pope's encyclical Mit Brennender Sorge was successfully read in churches across the nation, showing the limits of Nazi power. In the Protestant Church, the Confessing Church led a brave struggle that prevented Ludwig Müller's Reich Church from dominating German Protestants, proving that religious faith remained a powerful barrier to totalitarian control."

Interpretation 2: From Coercion and Consent by Professor Richard Bessel, published in 2004.

"Christian opposition to the Nazi regime was extremely limited, defensive, and ultimately failed to challenge the wider atrocities of the state. The vast majority of church leaders conformed to the regime because they shared Hitler's hatred of communism and feared the destruction of their institutions. When pastors like Niemöller spoke out, their protests were strictly limited to defending church independence and religious education; they did not protest against the police state, the banning of political parties, or the persecution of the Jews. The state successfully neutralized the churches through selective terror, arresting outspoken individuals while leaving the broader, compliant institutions intact."

3(a) Answer:
Source B is highly useful for evaluating the strength and typicality of Catholic resistance in rural Germany. The content reveals that the Catholic Church maintained a powerful hold over rural populations, noting that "the Nazi spirit cannot penetrate" because people believed "priests... rather than the words of our best party speakers". It is particularly useful for demonstrating the limits of Nazi control, showing that when the state attempted to enforce *Gleichschaltung* by removing crucifixes, popular protest forced them to back down. The provenance—a secret Gestapo report from Upper Bavaria in July 1937—increases its usefulness because it represents

an objective, internal assessment of Nazi failures, free from public propaganda. It proves that the Gestapo felt restricted by the Concordat, which prevented them from making direct arrests during services. Contextually, we know that Hitler signed the Concordat with the Pope in July 1933 to secure Catholic neutrality, but systematically broke it, making this 1937 Gestapo frustration highly representative of the ongoing religious friction.

Source C is extremely useful for investigating the motivations and nature of Protestant opposition. The content shows that pastors like Niemöller opposed the state-controlled Reich Church, accusing it of trying to "replace the Cross of Christ with the Swastika" and forcing children into Nazified youth organisations. It is useful because it shows the moral framework of the resistance, stating they "must obey God rather than men". The provenance—a sermon preached by Martin Niemöller in June 1937—is highly useful because Niemöller was the co-founder of the Confessing Church, which represented over 6,000 Protestant pastors resisting Nazification. The sermon shows that leaders were fully aware of the personal risks, acknowledging that speaking out would lead to "the concentration camps". Contextually, we know that Niemöller was indeed arrested by the Gestapo shortly after this sermon in July 1937 and imprisoned in Sachsenhausen and Dachau, validating the source's depiction of the state's ruthless suppression of religious dissent.

3(b) Answer:
The main difference is that Interpretation 1 argues that the Christian Churches successfully resisted the Nazi regime's attempts at total control, protecting their independence and preventing the Nazification of their institutions through active defiance like the Confessing Church and the Pope's encyclical.

In contrast, Interpretation 2 argues that Christian opposition was highly limited, narrow, and defensive. It asserts that the vast majority of church leaders conformed because they supported Hitler's anti-communist stance, and that when they did protest, they only defended their own institutions rather than challenging the regime's wider political terror or the persecution of the Jews.

3(c) Answer:
The interpretations differ because the historians have chosen to focus on different aspects of church behavior and have given weight to different sources. The author of Interpretation 1 focuses on institutional defiance and has given weight to evidence similar to Source B, which highlights the Gestapo’s frustration at being unable to break the "influence of the Catholic Church" and the successful popular resistance to the removal of crucifixes.

On the other hand, the author of Interpretation 2 focuses on the narrow scope of the opposition and has given weight to sources like Source C. While Source C is defiant, Niemöller’s sermon explicitly limits the protest to "church independence" and the defense of Christian youth education, rather than criticizing the regime's wider racial or political crimes, thereby supporting the view that church opposition was defensive and institutional.

3(d) Answer:
Interpretation 2 presents a highly convincing argument that Christian opposition to the Nazi regime was limited, defensive, and fundamentally conformed to the state’s wider political goals. To a very large extent, this interpretation is accurate. From my own knowledge, when Hitler was appointed Chancellor in January 1933, both the Catholic and Protestant Churches welcomed his anti-communist rhetoric. Terrified of the atheistic Soviet threat, religious leaders saw National Socialism as a vital shield. This shared ideological ground led the Catholic Church to sign the Concordat in July 1933, promising to withdraw from political activity in exchange for religious freedom. This agreement effectively neutralized Catholic political opposition.

Furthermore, as Source B demonstrates, even when priests or congregations protested, their actions were highly localized and defensive—focusing on maintaining "crucifixes" in schools rather than challenging the regime's wider atrocities, such as the destruction of democracy or the establishment of concentration camps.

However, Interpretation 1 provides a valid counter-perspective by demonstrating that the churches did present a genuine and successful barrier to total Nazification, which was the regime's ultimate goal under *Gleichschaltung*. From my own knowledge, when the regime attempted to merge all Protestant churches into a single, pro-Nazi Reich Church led by Ludwig Müller, it faced a massive revolt. Over 6,000 pastors, led by Martin Niemöller, broke away to form the Confessing Church in 1934. As Source C shows, these pastors openly refused to let the Swastika replace the Cross, and they withstood intense Gestapo terror. In the Catholic Church, when the regime closed Catholic schools and youth groups, Pope Pius XI issued the encyclical *Mit brennender Sorge* ("With Burning Concern") in 1937, which was smuggled into Germany and read from hundreds of pulpits, directly criticizing Nazi racial theories. These actions prove that on issues of core theology and institutional survival, the churches successfully defended their independence.

Nonetheless, the core assertion of Interpretation 2 remains valid because this opposition never broadened into a wider defense of human rights. Niemöller himself admitted that he supported early right-wing nationalist goals and only opposed the regime when it interfered with the Church. Crucially, during the systematic escalation of anti-Semitic persecution—including the Nuremberg Laws of 1935 and the violence of Kristallnacht in 1938—the official leadership of both the Catholic and Protestant Churches remained silent. Individual Christians, such as Dietrich Bonhoeffer, who actively joined the political resistance, were rare exceptions who were rejected by their own church hierarchies.

In conclusion, while the churches successfully preserved their institutional independence through brave, defensive resistance (as argued in Interpretation 1), I primarily agree with Interpretation 2. The opposition of the Christian churches was highly selective; they fought courageously to protect their own pulpits and youth groups, but their failure to speak out against the wider political terror and the persecution of their Jewish neighbors meant they ultimately conformed to Hitler's police state.

Enquiry: Religious opposition to the Nazi regime in the years 1933–39

3(a) How useful are Sources B and C for an enquiry into religious opposition to the Nazi regime in the years 1933–39? Explain your answer, using Sources B and C and your knowledge of the historical context. (8)
3(b) Study Interpretations 1 and 2. They give different views about religious opposition to the Nazi regime in the years 1933–39. What is the main difference between these views? Explain your answer, using details from both interpretations. (4)
3(c) Suggest one reason why Interpretations 1 and 2 give different views about religious opposition to the Nazi regime in the years 1933–39. You may use Sources B and C to help explain your answer. (4)
3(d) How far do you agree with Interpretation 2 about religious opposition to the Nazi regime in the years 1933–39? Explain your answer, using both interpretations and your knowledge of the historical context. (16+4 SPaG)

Turn over ▶